



Cambridge IGCSE™

COMBINED SCIENCE

0653/32

Paper 3 Theory (Core)

February/March 2026

MARK SCHEME

Maximum Mark: 80

Published

This mark scheme is published as an aid to teachers and candidates, to indicate the requirements of the examination. It shows the basis on which Examiners were instructed to award marks. It does not indicate the details of the discussions that took place at an Examiners' meeting before marking began, which would have considered the acceptability of alternative answers.

Mark schemes should be read in conjunction with the question paper and the Principal Examiner Report for Teachers.

Cambridge International will not enter into discussions about these mark schemes.

Cambridge International is publishing the mark schemes for the February/March 2026 series for most Cambridge IGCSE, Cambridge International A and AS Level components, and some Cambridge O Level components.

This document consists of **13** printed pages.

PUBLISHED**Generic Marking Principles**

These general marking principles must be applied by all examiners when marking candidate answers. They should be applied alongside the specific content of the mark scheme or generic level descriptions for a question. Each question paper and mark scheme will also comply with these marking principles.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 1:

Marks must be awarded in line with:

- the specific content of the mark scheme or the generic level descriptors for the question
- the specific skills defined in the mark scheme or in the generic level descriptors for the question
- the standard of response required by a candidate as exemplified by the standardisation scripts.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 2:

Marks awarded are always **whole marks** (not half marks, or other fractions).

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 3:

Marks must be awarded **positively**:

- marks are awarded for correct/valid answers, as defined in the mark scheme. However, credit is given for valid answers which go beyond the scope of the syllabus and mark scheme, referring to your Team Leader as appropriate
- marks are awarded when candidates clearly demonstrate what they know and can do
- marks are not deducted for errors
- marks are not deducted for omissions
- answers should only be judged on the quality of spelling, punctuation and grammar when these features are specifically assessed by the question as indicated by the mark scheme. The meaning, however, should be unambiguous.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 4:

Rules must be applied consistently, e.g. in situations where candidates have not followed instructions or in the application of generic level descriptors.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 5:

Marks should be awarded using the full range of marks defined in the mark scheme for the question (however; the use of the full mark range may be limited according to the quality of the candidate responses seen).

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 6:

Marks awarded are based solely on the requirements as defined in the mark scheme. Marks should not be awarded with grade thresholds or grade descriptors in mind.

Science-Specific Marking Principles

- 1 Examiners should consider the context and scientific use of any keywords when awarding marks. Although keywords may be present, marks should not be awarded if the keywords are used incorrectly.
- 2 The examiner should not choose between contradictory statements given in the same question part, and credit should not be awarded for any correct statement that is contradicted within the same question part. Wrong science that is irrelevant to the question should be ignored.
- 3 Although spellings do not have to be correct, spellings of syllabus terms must allow for clear and unambiguous separation from other syllabus terms with which they may be confused (e.g. ethane / ethene, glucagon / glycogen, refraction / reflection).
- 4 The error carried forward (ecf) principle should be applied, where appropriate. If an incorrect answer is subsequently used in a scientifically correct way, the candidate should be awarded these subsequent marking points. Further guidance will be included in the mark scheme where necessary and any exceptions to this general principle will be noted.
- 5 'List rule' guidance
For questions that require ***n*** responses (e.g. State **two** reasons ...):
 - The response should be read as continuous prose, even when numbered answer spaces are provided.
 - Any response marked *ignore* in the mark scheme should not count towards ***n***.
 - Incorrect responses should not be awarded credit but will still count towards ***n***.
 - Read the entire response to check for any responses that contradict those that would otherwise be credited. Credit should **not** be awarded for any responses that are contradicted within the rest of the response. Where two responses contradict one another, this should be treated as a single incorrect response.
 - Non-contradictory responses after the first ***n*** responses may be ignored even if they include incorrect science.

6 Calculation specific guidance

Correct answers to calculations should be given full credit even if there is no working or incorrect working, **unless** the question states 'show your working'.

For questions in which the number of significant figures required is not stated, credit should be awarded for correct answers when rounded by the examiner to the number of significant figures given in the mark scheme. This may not apply to measured values.

For answers given in standard form (e.g. $a \times 10^n$) in which the convention of restricting the value of the coefficient (a) to a value between 1 and 10 is not followed, credit may still be awarded if the answer can be converted to the answer given in the mark scheme.

Unless a separate mark is given for a unit, a missing or incorrect unit will normally mean that the final calculation mark is not awarded. Exceptions to this general principle will be noted in the mark scheme.

7 Guidance for chemical equations

Multiples / fractions of coefficients used in chemical equations are acceptable unless stated otherwise in the mark scheme.

State symbols given in an equation should be ignored unless asked for in the question or stated otherwise in the mark scheme.

Annotations guidance for centres

Examiners use a system of annotations as a shorthand for communicating their marking decisions to one another. Examiners are trained during the standardisation process on how and when to use annotations. The purpose of annotations is to inform the standardisation and monitoring processes and guide the supervising examiners when they are checking the work of examiners within their team. The meaning of annotations and how they are used is specific to each component and is understood by all examiners who mark the component.

We publish annotations in our mark schemes to help centres understand the annotations they may see on copies of scripts. Note that there may not be a direct correlation between the number of annotations on a script and the mark awarded. Similarly, the use of an annotation may not be an indication of the quality of the response.

The annotations listed below were available to examiners marking this component in this series.

Annotations

Annotation	Meaning
	correct point or mark awarded
	incorrect point or mark not awarded
	information missing or insufficient for credit
	incorrect or insufficient point ignored while marking the rest of the response
	contradiction in response, mark not awarded
	benefit of the doubt given
	error carried forward applied
	response is too vague or there is insufficient detail in response
	incorrect point or mark not awarded

Annotation	Meaning
SEEN	point has been noted, but no credit has been given or blank page seen
	key point attempted / working towards marking point / incomplete answer / response seen but not credited / blank page seen
BP	blank page
	unclear response
LNK	two statements are linked
FT	follow through
IR	irrelevant material that does not answer the question

Mark scheme abbreviations

;	separates marking points
/	separates alternative responses for the same marking point
ecf	error carried forward
AVP	alternative valid point
ORA	or reverse argument
AW	alternative wording
<u>underline</u>	actual word given must be used by candidate (grammatical variants accepted)
()	the word / phrase in brackets is not required but sets the context

Question	Answer	Marks
1(a)(i)	G ; E	2
1(a)(ii)	D ;	1
1(a)(iii)	glucose ; water ;	2
1(b)(i)	disease-causing organism / AW ;	1
1(b)(ii)	antibiotics ;	1
1(b)(iii)	<i>any two from:</i> hairs in the nose ; mucus ; stomach acid ; white blood cells ; AVP, e.g. ear wax ;	2

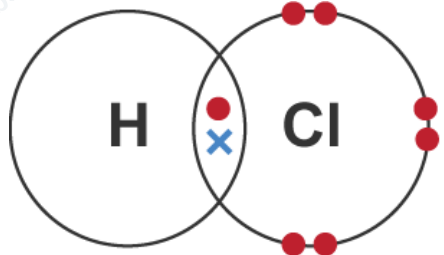
Question	Answer	Marks								
2(a)(i)	35 (°C) ;	1								
2(a)(ii)	from 40 (°C) to 50 (°C) ;	1								
2(b)(i)	<table><tr><th>large molecules</th><th>small molecules</th></tr><tr><td>fats and oils</td><td>fatty acids and glycerol</td></tr><tr><td>protein</td><td>amino acids ;</td></tr><tr><td>starch</td><td>glucose ;</td></tr></table>	large molecules	small molecules	fats and oils	fatty acids and glycerol	protein	amino acids ;	starch	glucose ;	2
large molecules	small molecules									
fats and oils	fatty acids and glycerol									
protein	amino acids ;									
starch	glucose ;									

Question	Answer	Marks
2(b)(ii)	carbon, hydrogen, oxygen ; nitrogen ;	2
2(c)(i)	provide energy ;	1
2(c)(ii)	<i>any two from:</i> vitamins ; minerals ; fibre ; water ;	2

Question	Answer	Marks
3(a)(i)	number ; species ;	2
3(a)(ii)	<i>any one from:</i> area for, housing / development / agriculture ; extraction of natural resources / mining ; destroyed by (named) pollution ; AVP, e.g. deforestation for, timber / wood / fuel / paper ;	1
3(a)(iii)	<i>any two from:</i> extinction ; loss of soil / soil erosion ; flooding ; increased carbon dioxide in atmosphere ; AVP, e.g. climate change / global warming / enhanced greenhouse effect ;	2

Question	Answer					Marks
3(b)	organism	producer	herbivore	secondary consumer	carnivore	4
	cactus	✓				
	rat		✓			
	snake			✓	✓	
	hawk				✓	
	 3333					

Question	Answer	Marks
4(a)(i)	<i>any one from:</i> effervescence / bubbles (of gas) ; solid / copper carbonate, disappears ; beaker feels warm ;	1
4(a)(ii)	copper carbonate + hydrochloric acid ; → copper chloride + carbon dioxide + water ;	2
4(a)(iii)	<i>any two from:</i> decrease the (hydrochloric acid) concentration ; lower the temperature ; use lumps / decrease surface area, (of copper carbonate) ;	2
4(a)(iv)	green ; red ;	2

Question	Answer	Marks
4(b)	bonding pair between the hydrogen and the chlorine ; three non-bonding pairs on the chlorine and no additional electrons ; 	2

Question	Answer	Marks
5(a)(i)	2,8,1 ; 20 ;	2
5(a)(ii)	lithium has 3 protons and 3 electrons / equal numbers of protons and electrons ; protons are positively charged and electrons are negatively charged ;	2
5(b)	<i>any two from:</i> decreasing melting point ; increasing density ; increasing reactivity (with water) ;	2
5(c)	<i>any one from:</i> act as catalysts (as elements and in compounds) ; form coloured compounds ; high, melting / boiling point ; high density	1
5(d)	zinc ; iron ;	2

Question	Answer	Marks										
6(a)(i)	C ₂ H ₆ ;	1										
6(a)(ii)	(g) circled ;	1										
6(a)(iii)	<table><tr><th>statement</th><th>true</th></tr><tr><td>It is the main constituent of natural gas.</td><td></td></tr><tr><td>It contains covalent bonds.</td><td>✓ ;</td></tr><tr><td>It is saturated.</td><td>✓ ;</td></tr><tr><td>It reacts with aqueous bromine.</td><td></td></tr></table>	statement	true	It is the main constituent of natural gas.		It contains covalent bonds.	✓ ;	It is saturated.	✓ ;	It reacts with aqueous bromine.		2
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It is the main constituent of natural gas.												
It contains covalent bonds.	✓ ;											
It is saturated.	✓ ;											
It reacts with aqueous bromine.												
6(b)	CH ₄ + 2O ₂ → CO ₂ + 2 H ₂ O ;	1										
6(c)(i)	incomplete (combustion) ;	1										
6(c)(ii)	carbon monoxide: toxic ; particulates: cancer / respiratory problems ;	2										

Question	Answer	Marks
7(a)(i)	evidence of $v = s / t$ OR 60 / 20 ; 3.0 ;	2
7(a)(ii)	at rest ;	1
7(b)(i)	(moving with) constant speed ;	1
7(b)(ii)	friction / air resistance / drag ;	1

Question	Answer	Marks
7(c)(i)	evidence of $p = F / A$ OR 7800 / 650 ; 12 ;	2
7(c)(ii)	particles move faster / have more (kinetic) energy ;	1

Question	Answer	Marks
8(a)(i)	crest R ; wavelength Q ; amplitude T ;	3
8(a)(ii)	evidence of $v = f\lambda$ / 300 000 000 ÷ 750 ; 400 000 / 4.0×10^5 ; hertz / Hz ;	3
8(b)(i)	total cost = cost per kWh × power in kW × time in hours / \$0.25 × 2.0 × 6.0 ; (\$)3.00 ;	2
8(b)(ii)	conduction convection radiation <i>one correct ;</i> <i>all three correct ;</i>	2

Question	Answer	Marks
9(a)(i)	charge / electrons ;	1
9(a)(ii)	1.5 (A) AND current at every point in a <u>series</u> circuit is the same ;	1

Question	Answer	Marks
9(a)(iii)	evidence of $R = V \div I / 9.0 \div 1.5$; 6.0 (Ω) ;	2
9(b)	helium AND hydrogen (circled) ;	1
9(c)	evidence of $W = mg / 72 \div 1.6$; ($m =$) 45 (kg) ; 45×9.8 ; $= 441 / 440$ (N) ;	4